THE WORLD NOW IS MULTIPOLAR ECONOMICALLY, UNIPOLAR MILITARILY AND FRAGMENTED POLITICALLY. INSTANCES OF OPPORTUNISM BY NATIONS ARE MULTIPLYING



By **SHIVSHANKAR MENON**

Each generation is convinced that it faces a more uncertain and threatening world than any before it, a crisis of unprecedented proportions, and that man's very survival is at stake. We are no exception, judging by the commentaries in the media. And yet, mankind has not only survived but steadily improved its lot. More people live longer, healthier and more prosperous lives than ever before in history.

One explanation for this paradox or contradiction between our objective condition and the way we perceive it is the idea of a world order. We have been conditioned into assuming that a world order is normal and beneficial by the bipolar Cold War and the subsequent unipolar moment, when first two and then one superpower dominated and ordered the world. One can understand why a hegemon would want us to think so.

THE PAST DECADE HAS SHOWN US THAT THERE IS NO WORLD ORDER CAPABLE **OF DEALING WITH THREATS LIKE CLIMATE** CHANGE, TERRORISM AND DEVELOPING COUNTRY DEBT CRISIS

But what do history and experience tell us? In fact, world orders have been the exception in history. For most of history, there has not been a world order. It is only when there is a tremendous imbalance in the distribution of power, as under the Mongols in the 13th century, with Europe in the late 19th and early 20th centuries and with the US and, briefly, the USSR after World War II, that there has been a world order. And those were not necessarily the most peaceful times. Unlike the Cold War, when over 80 per cent of world military and economic power was controlled by the two superpowers through their blocs, the two largest powers, the US and China, control less than 50 per cent of world GDP and military power today. Power, therefore, is much more evenly distributed in the world than in periods when a world order obtained.

History also tells us that the most innovative periods and the times when some of the most significant economic progress was made, were when the international order was disputed, often hotly. The Axial Age in the 6th century BCE and the industrial revolution of the 18th and 19th centuries occurred when warfare was endemic and the order was disputed. The re-emergence of China and India as significant economies on a global scale has occurred without a great power war. This suggests that the benefits of a world order may be exaggerated and overestimated.

And where are we today? Clearly, the world order that the West, led by the US, created and managed after WWII is disputed politically even while all countries are part of the global capitalist market system that order built. The ineffectiveness of the institutions of global governance and the multilateral organisations that underpinned the post-WWII order is evident in the pathetic international response to the Covid pandemic, in the decline of the WTO, and in the multiple conflicts and hotspots that are alive, ranging from Ukraine, Sudan, Palestine, Yemen, Congo to the Himalayas, the South China Sea, Taiwan, the East China Sea and multiple other areas. Great power rivalry is rampant, with China-US contention the principal contradiction. Deaths by conflict and refugees, both internally displaced and external migrants, are at record levels since WWII.

This is now a world between orders. In this respect, the world can be said to have returned to its normal state of competing powers of differing capacities and advantages seeking mastery and control over their own futures. Today, there is one globalised economy with at least three poles—in North America, the EU, and in Asia centred on China through the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP). On the other hand,